Angela M. Counts

Former Director of Admissions
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Angela M. Counts's career spans admissions leadership at Harvard University, undergraduate admissions and recruitment at USC and NYU, and student development at Cornell University. She coordinated K-12 biomedical research education programs at Harvard Medical School and oversaw the planning for the New England Science Symposium, fostering students' passion for scientific discovery. She has taught as an adjunct lecturer at Emerson College and the University of Arizona.

To Whom It May Concern,

I am pleased to offer my endorsement of Manan Singla and his research paper, “Platformisation in Smaller Indian Cities: A Literature Review of Informal Institutions, Labour and Technology Adoption in Urban Mobility.” As a former Director of Admissions at Harvard Divinity School, Harvard University, with experience in university admissions, recruitment, and student advising at institutions including the University of Southern California and New York University, I have worked with students navigating complex academic choices and identifying opportunities aligned with their interests and aspirations.

From this perspective, I find Manan’s research particularly relevant for the way it examines the relationship between technological innovation and the social, institutional, and economic realities that shape urban development. By exploring how informal institutions, labor arrangements, and local regulatory frameworks influence the adoption of digital mobility platforms in smaller Indian cities, his work highlights the importance of understanding technology within the wider context in which it operates.

Manan’s paper brings together literature on informal institutions, platform labor, algorithmic management, and transport governance to examine what happens when digital mobility models developed for large metropolitan markets are introduced into smaller cities. Rather than assuming that these models will produce similar outcomes everywhere, the paper considers how established practices, including driver unions and route-sharing norms, interact with platform incentives, state-level regulations, and local perceptions of trust, fairness, and value.

What I find particularly noteworthy is the paper’s emphasis on the importance of local context. Its central argument is that the success of digital platforms cannot be understood through technology design or demand projections alone. Existing social structures, labor arrangements, and regulatory frameworks also influence how these systems are received and adapted. By examining these factors together, Manan’s work offers a nuanced perspective on the relationship between technological innovation and the realities of everyday urban life.

The paper also considers the significance of open-network alternatives, including Namma Yatri, within the broader discussion of mobility platforms. By bringing academic research together with government and industry material, Manan seeks to understand how different approaches to platformization may respond to the needs of smaller cities. This makes the research relevant not only to discussions of digital innovation but also to wider questions of inclusive urban development, labor conditions, and the future of work.

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Throughout my career in admissions and college advising, I have valued students who look beyond the immediate subject of their studies to understand the wider economic and social forces shaping the world around them. Manan's research reflects this approach by connecting technological change with questions of labor, governance, and social institutions. It recognizes that innovation does not take place in isolation; its outcomes are shaped by the people, practices, and communities with which it interacts.

The completion of this literature review marks a meaningful step in Manan's research journey. His work reflects an effort to synthesize existing scholarship, identify connections across different areas of study, and develop a coherent argument about the conditions that influence technology adoption in smaller Indian cities.

I believe Manan's intellectual curiosity, analytical thinking, and interest in the intersection of technology and society are promising qualities. I am pleased to endorse his research and recommend him for academic opportunities that value independent thinking, interdisciplinary inquiry, and a thoughtful engagement with contemporary societal challenges.

Sincerely,



Angela M. Counts
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